

the user is yet to consider deploying his vacant terrace as a possible source of income.

Present-day rooftop installations are coming up primarily on the recent wave of capital cost reductions leading to reduced cost of electricity generation for captive consumption. The popularity and deployment of such systems is highly dependent on state electricity tariffs and availability of space for installations.

Opportunities and threats before system providers

According to Goel, as sunlight is available in abundance in India, the opportunities before solar system providers are vast. Threats linked to system providers, users and ultimately the whole market are:

1. Cheap, low-quality imports with no warranty or after-sale backup
2. High cost of finance
3. Vandalism and theft of installed arrays, batteries, cables, etc
4. Local social problems such as in the case of telecom towers powered by diesel
5. Slow and time-consuming process of approval of projects, release of subsidy, etc by state/central government agencies.

6. Poor quality of the grid and erratic breakdowns

To improve the market/operations, Goel suggests:

1. Free training camps for system providers, installers and technicians to impart good practices and international standard practices
2. Free/subsidised participation by stakeholders in general public awareness campaigns, exhibitions, seminars, etc
3. Appointment of approved agencies for carrying out audit of installations periodically and rating the overall project
4. Periodic interactive meetings by MNRE with stakeholders to understand the practical obstacles until the market reaches self-sustainable momentum.

A policy discussion paper by Prayas Energy Group argues that a balanced approach for promoting rooftop PV systems would be to adopt a national policy of 'net metering' to encourage in situ generation primarily for self consumption. Instead of further subsidising rooftop PV systems, tariffs of commercial and high-end residential consumers should be aligned with those of rooftop PV cost, thereby incentivising them to shift to solar or pay higher tariff. Policy should help create an enabling ecosystem for rooftop PV and focus on the removal of procedural hurdles and other barriers in order to facilitate the quick adoption and deployment of rooftop PV systems. ●

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